Before Something Happens

A safety guide for aging at home

A Quick Note Before You Start

This guide offers practical steps for enhancing the safety of your loved one's home. It's designed to be a helpful starting point, not a replacement for professional medical advice. Prioritize open communication and respect your loved one's autonomy throughout this process.

Disclaimer: This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute professional medical or safety advice.

Who This Guide Is For

This guide is designed for:

- **Adult children** checking on their aging parents.
- **Neighbors** who want to support seniors in their community.
- **Family members** involved in the care of an aging loved one.

It provides a straightforward approach to identifying and addressing common home safety hazards.

How to Use This Guide

This guide is structured as a quick walkthrough, focusing on key areas within the home. Use it as a checklist during your visits to identify potential risks. Small fixes can make a big difference! We've also included some things to look out for regarding well being, so you can start a conversation and seek medical assistance sooner rather than later.

The 10-Minute Home Safety Walkthrough

Focus on these key areas during your safety walkthrough:

- Entry and Walkways
- Lighting
- Bathroom

- Kitchen and Meals
- Mobility
- Phone and Emergency Access

Entry and Walkways

- [ ] Clear clutter from walkways (rugs, shoes, cords).
- [ ] Ensure rugs are secured or removed to prevent tripping.
- [ ] Check that outdoor steps and pathways are well-maintained and free of hazards.
- [ ] Install grab bars near entrances if needed.

Lighting

- [ ] Add nightlights in hallways and bathrooms.
- [ ] Ensure all rooms have adequate lighting (consider brighter bulbs).
- [ ] Place lamps within easy reach of beds and chairs.
- [ ] Check and replace any burned-out lightbulbs.

Bathroom

- [ ] Install grab bars in the shower and near the toilet.
- [ ] Use non-slip mats in the shower and on the bathroom floor.
- [ ] Consider a raised toilet seat for easier use.
- [ ] Ensure the shower chair is stable.

Kitchen and Meals

- [ ] Ensure frequently used items are within easy reach.
- [ ] Check expiration dates of food items regularly.
- [ ] Promote safe cooking practices (avoid leaving stoves unattended).
- [ ] Inspect electric cords of appliances for damage.

Mobility

- [ ] Assess the need for mobility aids (walkers, canes).
- [ ] Ensure furniture is stable and sturdy.
- [ ] Encourage regular exercise to maintain strength and balance.
- [ ] Help create accessible routes within the home.

Phone and Emergency Access

- [ ] Ensure the phone is easily accessible in case of emergencies.
- [ ] Program emergency numbers into the phone.
- [ ] Consider a medical alert system.
- [ ] Keep a list of medications and medical conditions readily available.

Small Fixes That Help Fast

- Secure loose rugs with tape or non-slip pads.
- Install brighter light bulbs.
- Move frequently used items to accessible locations.
- Remove clutter from walkways.

Early Signs Families Often Miss

- Increased clumsiness or falls.
- Difficulty with everyday tasks (dressing, bathing).
- Changes in mood or behavior.
- Forgetfulness or confusion.
- Neglecting personal hygiene.
- Unexplained bruising.

When to Act Faster

If you observe any of the following, it's crucial to seek professional help:

- Frequent falls or near-falls.
- Sudden changes in cognitive function.
- Signs of neglect or self-harm.
- Inability to manage medications.
- Worsening of existing health conditions.

Simple Visit Checklist

Use this checklist during each visit to assess safety and well-being:

- [ ] Home environment: Clear, well-lit, safe.
- [ ] Mobility: Steady, balanced, using aids if needed.

- [ ] Hygiene: Clean, well-groomed.
- [ ] Mood: Alert, engaged, positive.
- [ ] Communication: Clear, coherent, responsive.

The Real Goal

The true purpose of this guide isn't just about preventing falls or accidents. It's about promoting **independence, dignity, and quality of life** for your loved ones as they age at home. It's about being proactive and communicating effectively to ensure their safety and well-being.

About Red Desert Check-In

Red Desert Check-In provides in-person check-ins for aging adults who are still living independently. We look for practical changes' families may miss from a distance, including home safety concerns, food, mobility, routine, and general well-being. After each visit, family receives a clear update. When more support is needed, we can help point families toward trusted local connections for next steps.

This is not medical care, emergency response, or full-time caregiving. It is support for the in-between stage, before things become urgent.

Take the Next Step

Message Red Desert Check-In to talk through whether a check-in visit makes sense.

No pressure. No obligation.

Sources:

- CDC Falls and Fall Prevention: https://www.cdc.gov/falls/
- National Institute on Aging: https://www.nia.nih.gov/health/aging-place/home-safety